

RISKING IT ALL



Risking It All

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Anna Politkovskaya, a journalist for Novaya Gazeta, was the epitome of bravery and determination and a seeker of truth in the world, the Russian Federation, and the surrounding areas. She wrote stories about atrocities conducted by the Russian government and military, bringing light to the treatment of civilians by the government. Could she have been killed for what she had said or what she was about to say? To this day, no one has been held ultimately responsible for her death. She was harshly against the Kremlin and Vladimir Putin, which could point to a cover-up to prevent the real perpetrators from being brought to justice.

Politkovskaya was born and raised in New York and was the daughter of Ukrainian UN Diplomats. She had two children, a daughter Vera and a son Ilya. They were both grown at the time of her murder. She wrote six books and was the bravest of Russian journalists who presented a harrowing vision of a nation in chaos and the leader in charge of it. Anna Politkovskaya gained notoriety for her daring coverage of the Chechnya conflict as a lone voice screaming out in a moral wilderness. She then focused her steely gaze on the dangers to Russian stability, including Vladimir Putin. She presented a pervasive condition of degradation, and much of her writings are filled with compelling personalities and stories. An excerpt from her book *Putin's Russia*:

“ALL the murders of children that have taken place during shelling and moping-ups since 1999 have remained unsolved, uninvestigated by law enforcement agencies, child killers have not found themselves on the dock. And Putin never demanded this – although he is known as a great friend of all children. Why do I have it in for Putin? That's why I have it in for Putin. Because of his crudeness which is worse than thieving. Because of his cynicism. Because of racism. Because of endless war. Because of lies. Because of the gas at Nord-Ost. Because of corpses of the innocently killed, accompanying his entire first term as a president. Corpses that might have been avoided.” (Politkovskaya)

She describes an army where recruits are even farmed out as slaves, parents must offer money to retrieve their deceased sons' remains, and troops perish from starvation (Hearst).

She reveals widespread corruption in businesses, government, and the law, in which everything from business licenses to bus lines to judicial appointments is for sale. She also harshly criticizes the conflict in Chechnya, where rapes, torture, illegal assassinations, and abductions breed terrorism instead of putting an end to it. Furthermore, Politkovskaya criticized the West for its complete support of the Russian president as well as Putin for suppressing civil freedoms and pushing the nation back toward a dictatorship à la the Soviet Union.

In 2004, the Beslan school hostage crisis happened. Armed militants entered a school capturing about 1,100 people hostage. Anna tried to help. She used to work a lot in Chechnya and

thought that if she convinced Maskhadov, the Chechen President at the time, to come to Beslan to negotiate with the armed militants, the hostages would be released. Politkovskaya attempted to fly there to act as a mediator between authorities and the gunmen. On the plane there, she was poisoned and fell into a coma for two days. Thankfully she recovered, but unfortunately never made it to Beslan (Anna Politkovskaya Interview After Beslan 2004). There were 330 people killed in the Beslan school attack, most of whom were children in primary and secondary grades (The Editors of Encyclopaedia Britannica).

In an interview done right after the Beslan incident, she recounts the dangers of being a journalist in Russia and what happened. She said, “If you work as a journalist in Russia, you understand that it is a risky profession. When a miner goes down a mineshaft, he also knows that he might die. And it's the same for us.” She said that every week she received threats on her life. No one supported her nor the newspaper as it was against Putin. She said that they might have in words but not in actions. Journalistic solidarity in Russia did not exist, according to Politkovskaya (Anna Politkovskaya Interview After Beslan 2004).

She argues in the interview that the government has created a situation in Chechnya that is ripe for the production of terrorism. The government pushed people into corners with “completely stupid and pointless policies including – not only including – but principally those of Putin” (Anna Politkovskaya Interview After Beslan 2004). She says that that is what turned these men into beasts that would take children hostage and ultimately cause the death of 330 of those hostages.

In the interview, she talks about how dangerous her job is. She says that her children wanted her to stop, but she refused. They said it was too risky. What she was reporting on could get her killed. She said that that is all part of the job. She drew up a will and testament just in case something did happen to her (Anna Politkovskaya Interview After Beslan 2004). Anna chose to continue fighting for the people of both Chechnya and Russia, fighting for the truth and denouncing the government's actions and policies.

I believe that for this reason, on October 7th, 2006, outside her apartment building's elevator, Politkovskaya was shot four times at close range. She was constantly against the government and its policy and was a very harsh critic of Putin. She was a notorious Journalist that people read and listened to. At the time of her murder, she was completing a story on the probe into torture in Chechnya (Kaskinen). More than likely, the powers that be did not want that information to get out to the public, so they hired someone to assassinate her.

Anna Politkovskaya was a journalist who believed that not hatred but a love of humanity would save Russia and the world as a whole. Her exposé of Putin, I believe was cause for fear in the Kremlin, and it let the Russian people and the world know

just how corrupt and inhuman he is. What she stood for and what she went through was not lost to time. It still reverberates throughout the years. She was a shining beacon of truth in an otherwise dark pit of lies. Everything she wrote and all she did proves how brave she was in getting the truth out there about the corruption in the highest forms of government. She did not look at the risk as a block to the truth, only as a challenge to overcome. We could all learn from the bravery of this amazing journalist that put her own life on the line daily for the truth. The truth is worth fighting for, no matter the cost.

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David Beriain was a Spanish journalist who specialized in armed conflicts, violence, and immersion journalism. He was also a well known producer and documentary anchor. Beriain became known for presenting and directing the television show *Clandestino*, which primarily aired on Discovery Max (Wikipedia). To start off his career, David graduated from the University of Navarra with a degree in information sciences (Wikipedia). The University is located in Spain where he was also born and raised.

Beriain also worked for La Voz de Galicia in the international section from March 2001 to July 2007. He played an important part for this newspaper “during the second war in Iraq and the war in Afghanistan, where he covered the Spanish contingent in the city of Herat and the town of Qala e Naw” (Wikipedia). Later in 2012, he founded 93 Metros which is an audiovisual production company. This company specializes in “data journalism, audiovisual formats, and design of advertising content” (Wikipedia). David was able to create documentary films and a TV series that were successful and had to do with combat poaching.

His career ended up being the main reason behind his death unfortunately. As a journalist, he was aware that he was a large target, and that many people wanted to silence him. Approaching his death, he was working on a documentary about

efforts to combat wildlife poaching near the Arli National Park in southeastern Burkina Faso (Committee to Protect Journalists). David was working on this project with his camera operator, Roberto Fraile, when they were kidnapped and attacked. Later the next day it was reported that these attackers had taken the lives of Fraile and Beriain.

There is not much information on the actual work that Robert and David were able to accomplish during their last excursion, but it’s clear that the message must’ve been important enough for others to try and silence them. Beriain was a role model to many others in his company 93 Metros, and they all had good things to say about him. Adriano Moran, the cofounder of 93 Metros, was quoted in those reports describing Beriain as “one of Spain’s and the world’s great journalists”(Committee to Protect Journalists).

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Jeffrey Michael German was born on August 23, 1953, in Milwaukee, Wisconsin. He graduated from Marquette University and started as an intern for the Milwaukee Journal Sentinel (Mamnani 2022). Shortly after, German began building himself a very successful career with a podcast named "Mobbed Up: The Fight for Las Vegas," and an author known for his publications "Murder in Sin City: The Death of a Las Vegas Casino Boss" (Levenson 2022). Most of German's career included making impactful reports through headline-catching stories exposing mobsters and murderers, as well as corrupt officials and government agencies, for 20 years (Levenson 2022).

Jeff German reported on the death of 31-year-old Roberto Arce after North Las Vegas police officers restrained him. Joana, Arce's wife, was the one who called the police to the couple's home to seek medical attention for Arce due to strange behavior while under the influence of cocaine; she was also concerned for her three children, who were also present at the time. Arce was restrained due to his hostile behavior. It was stated that the officers shoved a dirty rag into his mouth, used excessive force to stop his breathing while he was on his stomach, placed a "bee mask" over his head, and ignored his complaints of difficulty breathing. Arce's death resulted from the officers' lack of training, and due to their wrongdoing, Arce's family filed a civil lawsuit against the North Las Vegas police department, which they fought for seven years (German 2009).

He was a passionate journalist who used his work to take down many powerful and dangerous people—ultimately making him a public target. Unfortunately, doing this type of work ended up costing him his life. On Saturday morning, September 3, Jeff German was found dead outside his home with multiple stab wounds. German published an article prior to his death regarding Robert Telles, a Clark County Public Administrator, and his mistreatment and inappropriate behavior toward his employees. This piece deteriorated Telles' re-election chances as Clark County Public Administrator, leaving him enraged with German. As a result, Teller was looked at as a prime suspect in

his murder, and later DNA found under Mr. German's fingernails confirmed this to be true (Las Vegas Review-Journal 2022).

Jeff German was not only a fearless reporter who always strived for justice and the truth, but he was also a man full of laughter and a loving and caring person to his family and friends. They say not all heroes wear capes, and Jeffrey Micheal German was a hero, taking on many powerful villains in an unjust world through his writing. Journalism is about seeking truth and voicing the injustice in society, but often at the expense of your own life. Jeff German will forever be honored for the courage and time he contributed to the community as a voice of truth and justice and an example to future journalists.

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We have learned from so many different types of journalists that have been killed or imprisoned for no wrongdoings, but on different topics they covered and the information they had held them accountable for these types of things. Many of their stories were just part of their job, however having such valuable information made them high value targets and consequences that included death, imprisonment, and even torture. Being an investigative journalist comes with many risks, but people who like this work, they love to be involved and place their own opinions on different things and people. While we usually think of journalists' killings and imprisonments happening in China, Russia, or the Middle East, they can happen right here in the United States. Although we already heard about several different journalists, this one will primarily focus on Jeff German, who was an American investigative journalist, he lived in Las Vegas and wrote for the Las Vegas Review-Journal, and the Las Vegas Sun.

Although Jeff German was born in Milwaukee but began his journalist career in Las Vegas and spanned over 40 years. Because Las Vegas is known as "Sin City" German thought that there would be plenty to cover and look for, and he started off his career by writing about casinos and gambling problems. "A Las Vegas betting expert was sentenced Thursday to 18 months in federal prison for running an illegal gambling operation and hiding money from the IRS. Tony Chau, 32, a Vietnamese immigrant who marketed an online wagering system to customers across the country, also was ordered to pay \$567,571 in restitution to the IRS and forfeit another \$1.4 million to the government." (German). As his reputation grew, he would start writing and investigative Las Vegas mobsters who found his work extremely corrupt and would often send threats to him about the "false information" that he was writing about.

The stories he wrote about, and the cases investigated on from the start of his career to about 2010 had been pretty minor, however after, his career took off and he became one of the most well-known journalists in Nevada. He would shift from his low-end writings to bigger things like failures in city inspections before a deadly hotel fire, alleged mismanagement by government officials, and local extremist groups. He then began writing plenty of articles about Robert Telles, who is the man responsible killing Jeff German. German would write articles about Telles, from his sexual assault and misconduct in his workplace, public relationships with coworkers and more. One included: "The re-election of embattled Clark County Public Administrator Robert Telles is in jeopardy after a lackluster showing in his primary battle with two Democratic challengers, including his top assistant." (German). This was because

German had written about Telles having an inappropriate relationship with his assistant.

Primarily, because of all these allegations against Telles, he lost a re-election bid in June 2022, and because of this, Telles' reputation had gone down significantly, and his work had also faltered. Because of this, Telles had showed up to German's house, "German was fatally stabbed on September 2, sustaining seven sharp force injuries, including four to his neck and one that cut his carotid artery." Telles was found guilty, although pleaded not guilty, he was charged for murder and his trial is set to begin in April 2023. Jeff German is a journalist that is not only important to investigative journalism, but to the City of Las Vegas because he was the most respected and well-known journalist there at the time. The stories he covered still are being discussed to this day and will be for the years to come because he never got to finish some of his investigations that left everyone involved with their head scratching what will come next. To me, I think that coming with this career has lots of risk factors that could potentially include death but is not worth it to me because a story to me is not worth a life and although some may disagree, it's really your choice how you use your voice and if you truly want to be heard enough.

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For as long as humanity has lived on this earth, there has been war and bloodshed. Peace is a localized phenomenon that can vanish just as quickly as it can appear. Before February 2022, most of the international community thought little of the Russo-Ukrainian Conflict. While many were sympathetic during the initial incursions in 2014, most chalked it up as some damned foolish event in the Donbas that would blow over eventually. However, some weren't willing to let this conflict fade into the background. Maks Levin was one of many journalists who risked their lives to keep the realities of war in the world's consciousness.

Levin, a Kyiv native, yearned to be a photographer from a very young age. However, it wasn't till after he graduated from university that he decided to pursue the profession full-time (Левин, 2016). According to Maks, he never set out to become a war photographer. When the Donbas conflict started in 2015, Levin immediately rushed to the Luhansk region, to cover the real situation along the front lines. There, he felt as if he finally found the stories that he was meant to cover all along (Akage).

Over the next eight years, he worked tirelessly to document how normal soldiers and everyday people dealt with the toll of trench warfare and routine conflict. He faced numerous close calls and was even awarded the Order of Merit for his daring escape from the Ilovaisk Pocket (Ukrayinska Pravda, 2022). However, like many other photojournalists, his luck ran out eventually.

The days leading up to Levin's death were not too dissimilar from many of his other days covering the Russo-Ukrainian Conflict. Practically hugging the front line, Levin was using a camera drone to gather footage of Russian maneuvers in the region near the village of Moshchun when he captured something important. We may never know what he saw that day, but Levin believed that the footage was so important that it was worth entering Russian-controlled territory to retrieve (the drone having been downed on March 10th). On the 13th of March, he jumped in his car and raced to the forests of Moschun, hell-bent on recovering the footage. He never made it home (RSF, 2022).

From this point on, we can only glean details from the surviving evidence on the scene of his execution. His car, charred and shot up, right next to a Russian trench position. His corpse, with two shots to the head and one to the chest, was found looted of all its valuable items. His phone, his press body armor, his shoes...all taken by his executioners. While the exact unit is still being determined, it is theorized that he was killed either by members of the Russian 106th Guards Airborne Division or deployed elements of the 64th Motorized Rifle Brigade of the Russian Army. Given the presence of DNA evidence at the scene, one can hope that one day, the perpetrators of this crime will be brought to justice (Froger & Chauvel, 2022).

The biggest tragedy of any wartime casualty is the people and ideals that the fallen leave behind. Levin was a husband and father of four sons. He valued freedom of information and freedom of the press and was a leading figure in the Ukrainian journalism community (Froger & Chauvel, 2022). He was also a major player in the Ukrainian fatherhood movement, believing that every father should play an active and nurturing role in their child's life; Something the war has taken away from his children forever (Ukrayinska Pravda, 2022).

Levin hoped that his work would lead to a peaceful world. One where everyone lives decently and honestly... that he would want his children to live in. There will come a time, hopefully soon, when this war will be over. The rubble will be cleared, the air-raid sirens will be silent, and children will live without the threat of death looming over them. Maybe then, will his hopes become a reality (Левин, 2016).

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Maria Elena Ferral Hernandez was a very well-known Mexican woman reporter. Maria lived in Papantla a region of the state of Veracruz. Maria was well known for her passion and commitment to end violence. She believed it was her duty to serve the community and try to make it a safer place to live. Maria understood that due to her job she was putting her life on the line, but that didn't stop her.

Maria Elena had a new column that she would post weekly, and it was named Polaca Totonaca (translated as the 'Politics of Totonaca'), Maria wrote about the politicians who had been murdered. A week before she was murdered, she put out an article recounting the incidents that happened to the four politicians that were murdered in Gutiérrez Zamora a small town in the state of Veracruz. In that article Maria blamed them for the murder and with that she had a big target on her back. She knew before posting this article she would be in trouble, but she did not care she wanted the article out there. Gutiérrez Zamora was known for its drug trafficking, transportation of legal products, and exploited women and immigrants. Gutierrez Zamora is the most dangerous place in Latin America for a reporter to cover (Carmona, 2020).

Before Maria was murdered there were three prior attempts on her on her life that she survived. Maria was well aware that they wanted her dead, but she wasn't afraid, and she was determined. Maria was a woman of intelligence, commitment, and passion. She was not afraid, and her main goal was to protect the

innocent while putting her life on the line at the same time. Maria Elena Ferral Hernandez was the 24th journalist to be murdered in Veracruz in the last eight years.

Maria was a woman who wanted to make change happen. Maria wasn't scared, she was determined to make Veracruz a safer place to live comfortably. In 2021 Maria was given the Courage in Journalism award in which her daughter accepted on her behalf. Her daughter talks about how proud she was of her mother. She talked so highly about her mother's commitment that she is now walking in her footsteps and is working towards being a journalist because she feels like her mother's work is not done. Maria Elena Ferral Hernandez was courageous and determined. She died fighting for something she was very passionate about and I hope her story makes an impact.

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In the Arab world, the state or the military controls the traditional media of tv and newspapers. Social networking on the Internet has made it possible for people to express themselves freely, voice their opinions, and communicate with others without restriction. However, people get monitored by what gets posted on the internet and social media. In Syria, there is extensive internet restriction. Syria blocks websites with political content and imprisons people who visited them. All chat forum comments are required to be recorded in Internet cafés (Wikipedia contributors).

Tal Al-Mallouhi is a Syrian student, poet, and blogger. She was only 19 years old when she was arrested in 2009 by Syrian authorities. It is unclear why the Syrian government has detained Al-Mallouhi. The court did not mention any detail or any supporting evidence in her case. Some Syrian activists are concerned that she might have been detained because of a poem she wrote about political and social topics on her online blog. Her writings also criticized some limitations on freedom of expression in Syria (Zackheim).

Tal Al-Mallouhi was detained after being called for questioning on December 27, 2009. State Security officials paid a visit two days later and seized her computer, several computer disks, notebooks, and a cell phone. No one from her family has been able to visit her after that date. Her mother issued an open letter to the Syrian president on September 2, 2010, requesting updates on her daughter's welfare and pleading for her quick release. Her mother said in the letter about the great pain her entire family had as a result of her daughter's arrest without a valid reason.

"I cannot describe to you the disaster that has befallen our family and what we're suffering. She is young and does not understand anything about politics ... One security branch promised me that my daughter would be set free before the advent of the blessed month of Ramadan. But Ramadan is almost over" (qtd. in Oweis).

Her family was finally permitted to see her for the first time at Doma Prison in Damascus on September 30, 2010; however, they have not been allowed to see her since. On February 12, 2011, the United States called for the immediate release of Tal Al-Mallouhi due to basic human rights of association and expression without worrying about retaliation from their own government.

"The United States strongly condemns Syria's secret trial of blogger Tal Al-Mallouhi, calls for her immediate release, and rejects as baseless allegations of American connections that have resulted in a spurious accusation of espionage. We call on the Syrian government to immediately release all its prisoners of conscience; and allow its citizens freedom to exercise their universal rights of expression and association without fear of retribution from their own government" (Crowley).

According to the Syrian regime's account, which Bushra Kanafani, Director of Foreign Media at the Syrian Ministry of Foreign Affairs, presented on February 23, 2011, Tal was recruited by an Austrian officer whom she met in Quneitra and got to know when she was 15 years old. She would later engage in espionage activities for the benefit of the United States (SHRC). Kanafani's account alleges that she later engaged in espionage activities for the benefit of the United States.

The State Security Court's ruling was final, and an appeal was not permitted. She was given a five-year jail term in 2011 for leaking national secrets. She was supposed to be released before the end of 2014, but she was not. Instead, she was found guilty of a fresh narcotics possession charge and given a three-year prison term. According to sources, she was transferred from Doma Prison to Damascus' State Security Division in 2016. As of the end of 2021, she was still being held (Amnesty International).

On her blog, Al-Mallouhi advocated for Palestinian rights and criticized Israeli government actions. It also covered Arab citizens' discontent with their rulers and what she saw as the Arab world's stagnation. She received a lot of attention from human rights advocates throughout the world as well as from the Arab blogosphere and social media platforms (CPJ). In some of Tal Al-Mallouhi's writing, she wrote poems that emphasized her hope for peace in the Middle East, limitations on free speech, and the suffering of the Palestinian people.

"You will remain an example [in reference to Gandhi]
I will walk with all the walking people
And no, I will not stand still just to watch the passers-by
This is my Homeland
I have a palm tree, a drop in a cloud, and a grave to
protect me
This is more beautiful than all cities of fog
And cities that do not recognize me
My master, I would like to have the power
Even for one day, to build the republic of feelings" (Al-Mallouhi).

Social media has undoubtedly had a significant impact on the development of politics and society. Citizens can now evaluate, balance, and exchange viewpoints. Youth who have been denied opportunities at every step now utilize social media as their main outlet to vent their rage and frustration in creative ways.

The idea of free speech in Muslim law is not explicitly defined. The opportunity of expressing one's own perspective was permitted but at the same time, a restriction was added, and it was very broadly and subjectively construed, requiring one to engage the conversation "in the best way." This commitment gives contemporary Arab politicians the power to severely restrict the right to free expression, demanding adherence to moral and ethical standards (Shishkina et al). One of the most common ways of governmental control of the media is internet censorship. Cyberspace is filtered for a variety of reasons,

including protecting societal religious, and moral ideals, preserving the security of the current regime, and attempting to restrict all forms of opposition movements. A censorial political culture, one that emerges in an environment often dominated by a single political party, continues to pose a danger to press freedom in Arab nations and the effectiveness of Arab journalists (Soengas). In the Arab news media of today and in journalism education programs, overt censorship and self-censorship are common, and the media has really been recruited into a national business for the manufacture of propaganda. As journalists find channels for reporting across transnational media through social media innovation, it will raise the demand for change and make concerns about censorship irrelevant.

The arrest of Tal Al-Mallouhi sparked a global outcry and condemnation from bloggers and human rights activists. protesters begged for information regarding her whereabouts, but the Syrian government has a policy of keeping silent on political arrests. Amnesty has stated that there are health issues for Al-Mallouhi due to her frailty and tachycardia, which is an unusually rapid heartbeat that can cause a drop in blood pressure and deplete oxygen from tissues and organs. According to reports, she was being held without medical care for her condition. Amnesty discovered 38 different types of torture and mistreatment of detainees in Syria. There are growing concerns that she may be tortured in various ways (Amnesty International). The Syrian government has been urged to release Tal Al-Mallouhi by many organizations such as Reporters without Borders, the Arabic Network for Human Rights Information, and Human Rights Watch.

In Syria, freedom of expression is consistently violated by the government. It demonstrates that Syria has no intention of improving its freedoms. Tal al-Mallouhi is believed to be the youngest female prisoner of conscience in the Arab world. Al-Mallouhi's case raises great concern not only in Syria but around the world. This will result in people rising up against their governments and religious authorities to put these nations back on the proper path of Islam and to move them toward the future rather than sticking to a hateful and unfortunate past.

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How can someone come to their death within their country's consulate? Although it may be hard to believe that became the fate of Saudi journalist Jamal Khashoggi on October 2, 2018. As he entered the consulate in Turkey to collect paperwork that stated his separation from his previous spouse he never walked out again.

Jamal Khashoggi was born on October 13, 1958, to a wealthy well- connected family in Saudi Arabia with ties to the royals. He lived and studied there until he moved to the United States to attend Indiana State University where he obtained a degree in business administration in 1982. He then launched his career in Journalism and became a correspondent for several different English and Arab language papers, including the *Saudi Gazette*, *Asharq Al-Awsat*, *Al-Majalla*, and *Al-Muslimoon*.(Dawn, 2021) Saudi Arabia is one of the most restrictive counties in the world. Although Khashoggi was a loyalist he was not afraid to voice his opinion which led to his dismissal on more than on occasion.

On May 21, 2018, Khashoggi publishes a column about the arrest of activist which stated "The message is clear to all: Activism of any sort has to be within the government, and no independent voice or counter-opinion will be allowed. Everyone must stick to the party line" (Pen, 2022). Could this have been what lead to his demise? In 2017 A year before his murder, Khashoggi went into self-imposed exile in the United States but a few months after started writing for the Washington Post. "In the United States, Khashoggi took full advantage of his new freedom. He wrote and spoke boldly, advocating for freedom of speech and democracy. He criticized the Saudi regime's imprisonment of political activists, and the Saudi's conduct in the war with Yemen, calling for a ceasefire and peace talks"(Dawn, 2021).

As this continued to develop Saudi rulers followed Khashoggi's activities closely because they were disturbed by the constant criticism of Saudi policies. They began to pressure Khashoggi to remain silent and when they saw that he was not defied they decided to escalate but were hesitant to do so as Khashoggi remained in the United Stated. When they obtained information that he would be traveling abroad they seized the opportunity. "By the time Khashoggi entered the Saudi Consulate in Istanbul in the early afternoon of October 2, 2018, the Saudis had flow in

a special operations team to murder the defiant dissident". (Dawn, 2021) Leading to the investigation upon the crowned Prince of Saudi Arabia and the contradicting information on how the death of Jamal Khashoggi unfolded.

Is this what comes with advocating freedom of speech and democracy? Journalism can become a very dangerous career if you offend, uncover, or contradict someone with power. How is that far? We are supposed to be aware of what is happening in this world and unfortunately those with power/dictation want to hide it. Journalists are only reporting what they find is important for people to know and feel like it is being hidden from the public eye. They voice their opinion because they know that there are millions of people that have the same perspective as they do, and they want to make a change. Silencing them will only infuriate those seeking the change and they will begin to retaliate. The worst thing is that the people responsible for these acts go unprosecuted. I can only imagine the mixed emotions those close to Mr. Khashoggi felt when they couldn't find a concrete answer as to had transpired behind those closed embassy door back on October 2nd, 2018. The fate of Jamal Khashoggi is one that no one wishes to come across.

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Daphne Caruana Galizia. Does this name ring a bell to anyone? It should. She was the first prominent female journalist in Malta. At the time, “[newspaper] articles either did not carry bylines or were published under a pseudonym [in Malta]” (The Daphne Caruana Galizia Foundation). Instead, Daphne Caruana Galizia chose to publish her journalistic work under her own name. Before we continue on, let’s start from the beginning of her life.

Daphne Caruana Galizia was born on August 26, 1964 in Sliema, Malta to Michael And Rose Vella. She was educated at St. Dorothy’s Convent School and St. Aloysius College. Her first exposure to Malta’s political system occurred at the age of eighteen, when she was arrested for participating in anti-government protests. As a result, Daphne Caruana Galizia “never lost her outrage against [the] authoritarian government” (Borg). Later on in life, Daphne Caruana Galizia reflected that “What happened in the 1970s and 1980s was possible because people gave in”. She continued on to say that “They complied, they lowered lowered their heads below the parapet, and they worked with corrupt and abusive scum to ensure their own survival rather than defying them, [all] for the sake of a quiet life” (Daphne Caruana Galizia Quotes). This situation was one of the first steps toward her future journalistic career.

In 1988, Daphne Caruana Galizia began writing a column for “The Sunday Times of Malta”. “Her column was unusual for its time — [it was] a mix[t]ure of commentary, opinion, reportage and analysis” (The Daphne Caruana Galizia Foundation). Later on, Daphne Caruana Galizia helped establish the “The Malta Independent”. She became the associate editor of it. Her colleagues “remember her as [a] meticulous and hard-working [woman], [who was] not always easy to get along with” (Borg). Daphne Caruana Galizia began to branch out her journalistic career through a different avenue.

In March of 2008, Daphne Caruana Galizia began a blog called “Running Commentary”. The first post published was titled “Zero Tolerance For Corruption”. Daphne Caruana Galizia ran her blog “Running Commentary” independently. She once stated that “It’s true that life is unfair and that much of it can’t be helped, but where I can do anything to avoid unfairness or to set it straight, then I will” (Daphne Caruana Galizia Quotes). Her blog became an avenue for her to report on the corruption, sleaze, and crime in Malta. Not to mention, “it quickly became [one of] Malta’s most popular independent news website” (Borg). “Running Commentary” attracted “a daily readership that averaged [about] 400,000 and sometimes up to a million” (The Daphne Caruana Galizia Foundation).

Daphne Caruana Galizia reached the pentacle of her journalistic influence in 2016. She posted a story “about [the] secret Panamanian companies that two top government politicians had set up just days after getting into power” (Borg). Her news story then continued on, Michelle Muscat —the wife of Malta’s Then Prime Minister Joseph Muscat — also owned a secret company in Panama. Prime Minister Joseph Muscat claimed that these

allegations against him were unfounded. And it led him to called Malta’s 2017 General Election a year earlier than it was scheduled. This resulted in a victory for the Labor Party (of which he’s a member of). Daphne Caruana Galizia stated that the Labor Party’s victory was pre-planned ahead of the time. But her report was met with skepticism. As she stated “I don’t think standards can fall any further, really, unless we catch [the Prime Minister] Joseph Muscat fornicating with a sheep on a bed of hard cash”. She continued on with “And even then, thousands of people will say “It’s [his] private life.” [or] “Where’s the proof.”” (Daphne Caruana Galizia Quotes). This was not the first time that Daphne Caruana Galizia had challenged someone in power. But this time was a little different.

On October 16, 2017 Daphne Caruana Galizia was driving near her home in Bidnija, when her car suddenly exploded. She was killed instantly. Her remains were later found by a family member. At the time, this was the sixth car bombing attack to occur in Malta since 2016. Prime Minister Joseph Muscat did not immediately arrange a public inquiry into the death of Daphne Caruana Galizia. Corinne Vella, Daphne Caruana Galizia’s sister, stated that Prime Minister Joseph Muscat downplayed her death and “[is] working to[ward] transform[ing] her into a martyr for [the Labor Party’s] cause” (The Malta Independent).

In conclusion, the nature of Daphne Caruana Galizia’s journalistic work was controversial in Maltese society. As a result, numerous threats of violence were made against her. Despite these risks, she continued to uncover corruption in Malta until her death. She once stated that “All others have the law on their side and all they need is the tenacious personality to withstand constant harassment that is the fruit of corruption and abuse of power” (Daphne Caruana Galizia Quotes). Her very own words are a reflection of the type of person that she was. Daphne Caruana Galizia was a fearless woman, who was a true advocate for the freedom of speech even when in the face of adversity.

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PM Noticias was founded by Pablo Morrugares, who was the main editor of the website. This website was generally known for covering local news, politics, and crime around the city/state of Guerrero (CPJ. 2020). In the beginning of 2020, he covered a lot about the effects that the Covid-19 pandemic had on the state of Guerrero, which some people did not agree on. His success came from his news reports since he had a background in the Mexican government that allowed him to dig deeper into the news he was publishing. Pablo was also not scared of the trouble he could be facing by reporting these kinds of events in Guerrero's most dangerous and controversial city. Little did he know, though, he was digging up his own grave by doing so.

Before opening up his own website, Pablo was under the administration of Jose Luis Abarca, who was involved in the Mexican government, working as a spokesman for him. On November 4, 2014, Jose Luis was in a huge controversy when he was arrested for being involved in the abduction and assassination of 43 college students on September of the same year. That caused many riots and threats to anyone that was close to the mayor, including Pablo Morrugares. "Local media reported that threats against Morrugares had been displayed on banners hung by roadsides, a tactic frequently used by drug gangs in Mexico" (AP, 2020). Morrugares was given police protection in 2016, after he and his wife escaped gunmen shooting at their car one night as they were heading home. They were placed in a safe house from 2018 to the end of 2019. When 2020 came, he decided to leave the safe house on his own, but was given two bodyguards in case there was another threat against him.

On August 2, 2020, right before 1AM, two heavily armed men walked into a restaurant firing more than 50 shots at Pablo, who died instantly. A police officer, who was his bodyguard as well, also died in the attack (CPJ, 2020). The media had a lot to say about this occurrence but the main question was, what drove those men to do this? Two months before this happened, "Pablo was threatened in a facebook video by a criminal gang from Iguala, according to journalist Omar Bello Pineda that is part of the Mexican Association of Displaced and Attacked journalists" (CPJ, 2020). Before his assassination, Morrugares was also reporting about some crime activity outside of a supermarket that involved two criminal gangs fighting for territory. This was

another reason to think that all of these events tie back to the reason for his death.

Sadly, none of this has stopped the killings of journalists around the globe. "In 2019, 10 journalists were murdered in Mexico, according to the NGO Reporters Without Borders. More than 100 journalists have been killed in Mexico since 2000, with only a fraction of those crimes resulting in convictions" (MP, 2020). Most of these numbers have doubled since organized crime gangs have increased in the Mexico region. The sheer thought of this happening and nothing big being done about it is absolutely heartbreaking, especially for the family of the victims. In Pablo's case, 8 suspects were arrested for having connections to his murder. The Guerrero's state prosecutor's office announced that the guys connected to Pablo's murder were in Iguala, hiding in a safe house. At that location, they saw a burning car that could have possibly been used in his killing. To this day, they still don't know who the main killer is.

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In August of 2019, a journalist living in the small town of Actopan, Mexico was murdered. His name was Jorge Celestino Ruiz Vazquez and he was journalist for a newspaper called El Gráfico. At the time of his death, he was supposed to be under security protocols, but never received them and it resulted in his death. This led to speculation as to what else was at play.

Jorge was a journalist in his local area. He had reported previous death threats and one time his house was even shot at. The night of his murder, he was granted protective custody, but it was never given to him. The governor of Veracruz launched an investigation because of this. As it turns out, the man that he was killed by was hired by the mayor of his town. He was working on a story talking about how critical he was of the mayor and because of this, the mayor had him killed. The man that killed him was sentenced to 32 years in prison and the mayor that orchestrated the killing was placed under investigation. I was not able to find out what happened to the mayor, but the governor of Veracruz said that he would find out who killed Jorge and they would take responsibility for their actions. Because of all this evidence, it seems that the mayor was the one that prevented the security from being with Jorge and thus led to his death (Sentenciaron, 2022).

It is difficult to find detailed information about the death circumstances of Jorge, but after his murder, the death toll for journalists in 2019 was up to 10 by August. Mexico has continually had a problem with journalists facing threats of violence and death threats. This is usually because of the cartels and other organized crime and that they are usually linked to political powers. This is another theory about the mayor that hired someone to kill Jorge. I think it is extremely possible that he could have been working with the cartel before. I could not find any specific articles, but I know that Jorge was critical of the mayor and that could have been one of the reasons. He might have begun to realize that the mayor was working with organized crime leaders and the mayor needed to silence them. Another reason that it is so dangerous to be a journalist is because many of the murders go unsolved, so the killers are never prosecuted. Usually, the government says they will do something about it, but nothing ever happens, and the families are left with no answers as to what happened (Deutsche, 2019).

This case should be talked about more because we need to show that just because someone is in a position of power, they cannot and should not get away with whatever they want. There are many cases in which politicians or other powerful people seem to be able to get away with something in which they have

irrefutable evidence stacked against them. While legally they are not prosecuted, the citizens still lose their trust in that person. Although this is smaller scale, it still cost someone their life and I am unable to tell whether the right people got what they deserved. There should never be a fear for journalists to lose their life for reporting on a story, especially if it is on the government. The government needs to be transparent for the citizens to trust them and journalism is an easy way to make the government transparent. The case of Jorge Celestino Ruiz Vazquez perfectly exemplifies this. It was well known that he did not like the policies of the mayor in his town and he was not able to report on it without facing adversity and eventually being killed. I hope for the future that we are able to mitigate this issue so that journalism can be practiced freely.⁵

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In the year 2020, there were a recorded 32 journalists that had been killed with a confirmed motive. Amongst these 32 journalists was a woman who went by the name of Malalai Maiwand; she was only 25 years old when she was murdered.

On December 10, 2020, in Jalalabad city in Afghanistan, Malalai was on her way to work with her driver Mohammad Tahir, when their car was opened, fired upon and they were both killed. The Islamic State came out and claimed responsibility for the shooting and called Malalai a pro-regime journalist. This attack may not have come as a surprise as Malalai had stated before she was killed that she was receiving death threats from the Islamic State and the Taliban. It was said that they wanted her to stop reporting.

Malalai was a new presenter for Enikass Radio and TV and she had worked there for five years. She had spoken out against injustices, the ongoing war and violence, and the challenges of being a female journalist in Afghanistan. Since she was a journalist and a woman, she was given unique access to stories and was able to talk to widows and orphans. Malalai would often report on human rights issues and government corruption. She was described by her colleagues as “strong and compassionate”, “a brave, top-notch journalist with open eyes” (Razdan), and “a woman that gave confidence to other women” (Glinski).

Malalai was inspired by her mother as her mother was also a women’s rights activist. But her mother was killed five years before Malalai by an unidentified gunman. Also, Malalai was not the first Enikas employee to be a target of an attack, in 2018 the station’s owner, Engineer Zalmay, was kidnapped and held for ransom (Janjua). This truly shows that Malalai was a brave woman to continue to speak out for what she believed in despite the violence going on around her and the threats she received.

Now being a young woman that was a journalist in conservative Afghanistan gave her a good amount of attention. Aziz Tassal who is a director of the Kabul Press Club said that Malalai “rose to prominence three years ago after delivering a fiery speech in front of the president on rising corruption in her native Nangarhar province” (Razdan). During her speech, she said to the president “you are surrounded by corrupt people” showing that she was not scared nor was she going to let anyone stop her from speaking the truth.

What is so terrible about all of this is Malalai is not the first journalist to be targeted simply because she was a journalist.

Just 24 hours after Malalai’s death a television presenter, Fardin Amini, was found dead under mysterious circumstances (Razdan). Malalai was the fourth journalist to be killed in Afghanistan in 2020. The three journalists Elias Daei, Yama Siawash, and Zamir Amiri were all targeted and killed in explosions (“Afghanistan”). It is truly sad to see these journalists get killed because they want to use their voices and speak out. No one should have the fear of being killed just trying to deliver stories and do their jobs.

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Between the years of 2019 and 2020, 100 journalists died and among them was Nabil Hasan Al-Quaety, a married father of four, who was murdered outside his home in Aden in a planned assassination on June 2nd, 2020 (CPJ). He was only 34 years old and worked as a freelance journalist and photographer and was working with the French public broadcaster Agence France-Presse or AFP. During his time in Yemen, the capital city Sana'a was under control of Houthi Rebels who are allied with Iran. Both the Yemeni Government and the Southern Transitional Council (STC) are fighting against the Houthi Rebels (Yemeni Journalist). In August of 2019 the STC turned on the Yemeni government and Seized the city of Aden where Al-Quaety lived (CPJ). Al-Quaety had supported the STC and was criticized by the members of Islah, a bloc of the Yemeni Government, who also accused him of being funded by the United Arab Emirates who was working with the STC (Yemeni Journalist). His assassination was the first targeted killing of any media worker since 2015 when al-Qaida killed a journalist in Sana'a (Yemeni Journalist).

Before Al-Quaety had been murdered he had traveled to Yemen in 2015 to cover the Civil War that started in 2014 between the Yemeni Government and the Houthi Armed Movement as well as the humanitarian crisis caused by the conflict of the war (JPost). He had been awarded for his reports on the civil war in 2016 by Britain's Rory Peck Awards so he was a notable figure when it came to reporting on the civil war in Yemen. Unfortunately his killers escaped and have not been found to this day even with Yemen's Government calling for an investigation (Al-Monitor). The first group who is suspicious of the crime would be the Houthi Rebels who are against the STC and Yemen Government although it is also possible, albeit unlikely, Yemen's Government themselves are behind it due to the group Islah, who is a part of the Yemeni Government, disliking Al-Quaety's support for STC who had control over the city he lived in.

Following his death the Global News Director Phil Chetwynd of the news agency AFP who Al-Quaety was working for said, "We are shocked by the senseless killing of a courageous journalist doing his job despite threats and intimidation. Through his work with AFP over the past five years Nabil had helped to show a global audience the full horror of the conflict in Yemen. The quality of his work had been widely recognised. The thoughts of everybody at AFP are with his wife and children today" (AFP). His wife has not spoken in public or to any reporters about her husband. The undersecretary at Yemen's

information ministry, Najib Ghallab, stated, "We condemn this crime against Quaety, whose work was to cover events and facts in pictures. It seems that his work has caused outrage among some extremist parties" (AFP). Lastly the STC, who Al-Quaety supported, has this to say, "It is with great sadness and pain that the STC mourns the martyrdom of the war photographer Quaety in a treacherous terrorist operation" (AFP).

The death of Nabil Hasan Al-Quaety was tragic and a severe loss for many. The pain that his wife and children must feel is unimaginable. Al-Quaety was an amazing journalist and put his life on the line to report on the civil war in Yemen. He knew the dangers of his job and even after a brush with death in 2019 when he survived a deadly Houthi drone attack on al-Anadair base while he was covering a military parade he still continued to report on the war and stand up to the ones who cowardly killed him (Al-Mashareq). We need more journalists like Al-Quaety and the loss of any of them is tragic. His reports on the war for nearly 5 years were crucial in spreading awareness about the war and supporting the people of Yemen through the tough times. He will be missed.

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Mexico has a history of murder, imprisonment, and disappearances of journalists. According to Reporters Without Borders, “More than 150 journalists have been murdered in Mexico since 2000.” Unfortunately, many government officials have a history of undermining investigations due to collusion with cartels, and the disappearance of journalist María Esther Aguilar Cansimbe is no different (“Mexico”). Aguilar left her house in Zamora on November 11th of 2009 and was never seen again (“Crime Reporter Missing”).

María Esther Aguilar Cansimbe wrote for two different dailies, *El Diario de Zamora* and *Cambio de Michoacán*. She was a mother of two, and was married to police chief David Silva. Aguilar frequently wrote about cartels and corruption in the government. She often had to omit her name from the byline of the articles that she wrote because of the risks posed to the well-being of herself and her family if she was associated with the stories. She had recently published both a story about abuse of authority by a local police official and a story about two top members of a local crime organization called The Family. It is suspected that she disappeared as a result of these articles (“María”).

In the weeks and months following the disappearance of María Esther Aguilar Cansimbe, the investigation had gone nowhere. The Committee to Protect Journalists had contacted local authorities to try to encourage the investigation, but nothing ever came from it. According to the Michoacán State Justice Attorney General’s Office, there were numerous reports written, but Aguilar’s family insists that no one got in touch with them, and they claim that her case file was just being passed from office to office (“One Month”). Since 2009, there haven’t been any updates on the investigation. It’s nearly impossible to find unique information about her case, with a multitude of websites repeating the same information about the mystery of her disappearance, with nothing to add since she first vanished. Her articles that were most likely the cause of her disappearance are nowhere to be found on the internet today, or, if they are

available, are untranslated from Spanish. Aguilar was included in Time Magazine’s “10 'Most Urgent' Cases of Threats to Press Freedom” in September of 2020 in order to bring attention to journalists throughout the world who are still missing (TIME).

As a woman who risked her personal well-being to report on corrupt government and high-profile crime organizations, María Esther Aguilar Cansimbe should be remembered. She saw the need to share information with the world, doing what it takes to bring the corrupt to justice. Unfortunately, even though she took steps to protect herself, she still wasn’t able to avoid the consequences that many journalists throughout the world have faced for their bravery. We can only hope that one day something will come of the investigation into her disappearance, so that her family can have the peace of mind in knowing what happened to her.

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On May 4, 2019, Ukrainian journalist Vadym Komarov was attacked. He was found on a central street unconscious with a broken head by a passerby walking in the morning at about 9.30 a.m..(Institute of Mass Information) Vadym Komarov was only 57-years-old when he was brutally assaulted by an unidentified individual in his hometown of Cherkasy, a city in central Ukraine. After being found he was hospitalized and medically induced into a coma for six weeks. Despite this, the injuries were too severe and Vadym passed away in the hospital June 20, 2019 (Martinovic). These, however, are only the circumstantial, undeniable, basic facts of Vadym's untimely death. I would like to shine some more light on this journalist's death, or rather more appropriately said, murder. For Vadym was not simply attacked, and didn't simply die due to "circumstance". He was targeted, deliberately killed, and, like many truth-bearing, outspoken, and honest journalists of the world – silenced.

Vadym was like any man, living his ordinary life with his beloved wife, making money with freelance work on his social media, as well as writing and reporting for the local daily *Dzvin*. Denys Kolesnyk, a colleague of Komarov, spoke about him as being a very kind and loving person. But at work his personality was more fearless and daring, as Kolesnyk stated, he was not afraid to name people in his stories (ctd. in Melkozerova). Another acquaintance of Vadym's, Borysiuk, told the Kyiv Post: "What I liked in him as a journalist was his bite. If he took a topic, he would get to the bottom of it. He was like a track hound when it came to digging and reporting," (qtd. in Melkozerova). Komarov's bravery and brutal honesty were rare attributes for Ukrainian journalism, and as admirable as that may be, they were also a leading cause to his murder. In digging into the truths for his reports, he posed as an inconvenience for those who were in control of local Cherkasy politics. "He raised annoying questions about corruption in Cherkasy, raised important topics that resonated in the society," Tomilenko, head of the National Union of Journalists of Ukraine, told CPJ. In trying to find a voice of truth for his community and the people of Cherkasy, he "poked his nose" too much into corrupted politicians' scandalous behavior. He became a problem that needed to be "taken care of".

However, being the local "mafia" main pain in the neck was no surprise for Komarov. The Ukrainian journalist had received multiple threats throughout his career, and even survived other attempts on his life in the past. Vitaly Chernukha, chief architect of the Cherkasy city council and one of Komarov's close friends, recalled one of these attempts. "Somebody rang the door, Vadym went to open it. He stuck his head out of the door and saw a man pointing a gun at him. He managed to hide and the bullet hit the wall where his head was a moment earlier" (qtd. in Melkozerova). Another assault the architect shared happened in 2017, when Komarov was shot at in the hall of a residential building. This attack left him with a wounded leg. "The police even gave Vadym a bulletproof vest that time" Chernukha later added (qtd. in Melkozerova). But it's that last

statement that reveals one of the biggest issues in this whole story. Even with these multiple attacks on Komarov's life and open evidence of direct threats, the local authorities did close to nothing in ensuring the journalist's safety. And this negligent behavior has likewise transitioned into the actual investigation of Vadym's death.

In doing my own research, I attempted to find Vadym's Facebook page to inspect his previous works, and get a clearer picture about what he was fighting against. However, according to authority's report, Komarov's family had deleted the journalist's electronic files before police could examine them, on the grounds that they could contain personal images and documents, and other reliable sources of information about what the journalist was working on (CPJ). This only made me more suspicious of the circumstance of this particular murder case and the Ukrainian officials' involvement in it all.

It's been over a year later and authorities still have not claimed and persecuted anyone for the murder of Vadym Komarov. Moreover, they have made little to no progress in bringing justice to the case. [Investigations](#) have stalled and no new suspects have been publicly identified (Martinovic). Worst of all, officials to this day don't confirm or acknowledge that this murder was the result of Komarov's bold journalism. They proceed to entertain different theories, such as unresolved arguments, a robbery, and etc. Yet everyone who was close to Vadym and knew his work unanimously agree, that "the only reason for an assault and subsequent death of Komarov was his journalism." (Tomilenko qtd. in CPJ). Colleges and a number of national organizations have even signed an open letter on May 4, 2020 urging for regional authorities to be more transparent about the investigation. The [letter](#) said it "would allow all of us to believe that the death of our colleague is not another unpunished crime and that the perpetrators will be found and brought to justice" (Martinovic). Even outside of the journalist's home country, this murder story and lack of resolution has raised concerns. European co-rapporteurs and Ukraine monitors Dzhenia Grozdanova (Bulgaria) and Alfred Heer (Switzerland), have requested that local Ukrainian powers ensure that an effective investigation take place. They emphasized that Vadym's professional activity as an investigative journalist reporting on corruption and abuse of power in Cherkassy being directly linked to his [murder](#), makes the case all the more concerning. (Belgium).

But have any of these attempts from both local and abroad journalist associations lead to any progress in bringing justice to Komarov's death? No. Since it's the very same corruption driven authorities that are in play, who are most likely working with those that Vadym was speaking out against. It is suspected that local ties between law enforcement and powerful individuals are involved and makes keeping this case unsolved within their best interests. Unsurprisingly, impunity for the murder of journalists is common in Ukraine. According to IPI's [Death Watch](#), Komarov was one out of eleven victims in

Ukraine killed for their journalism in the last six years (Martinovic). And such a negligent response on authority's part sends out a concerning message to local journalists throughout the country. According to Tomilenko, Ukrainian journalists previously killed have been for the most part all well-known public figures, whereas, "The murder of Komarov was alarming for regional journalists. They realized that living in small communities means that they are even more unprotected than their nationally well-known colleagues...they were afraid of becoming the next victims" (qtd. in Martinovic). In such circumstances and cases, a lack of a response tends to be the loudest response.

Again, I can't say any of this surprises me. Growing up with two Ukrainian parents, my family made regular trips to their home town of Kharkov. As a little kid my entire summers were spent living in small Ukraine towns, playing with local children, shopping at bazars, and experiencing what most Slavic children grow up with. This includes seeing parents and surrounding adults participate in casual bribery with local authorities. This practice being so common and socially accepted that it was only after learning about it in American schools did I realize how immoral it was. I have vivid memories of daycares collecting money from our parents to pay off the 'cop tax' so that the local mafia won't 'touch' the schools. Or how my father, after getting pulled over in traffic, a normal weekly occurrence, would simply open his wallet so that the officer could choose how much hryvna (Ukrainian currency) to take. If this is the kind of behavior even little children as myself were exposed to, I can only imagine what goes down on local political levels.

Corruption in Slavic countries such as Ukraine has become as normalized and accepted as traffic laws or common courtesy. And speaking out against them or pointing out authority's involvement in it all is considered socially wrong and dangerous. Everyone is aware that in doing so, you're putting an unwanted target on your back. Truth seeking journalists get called insane or even stupid for their work, strives, and efforts in

anti-corruption. However, the only words I can find to describe these journalists, such as Vadym Komarov, are "selfless" and "brave". Even though they knew the risks of putting themselves in such a spotlight, they willingly choose to speak for the truth and what's right. And it was this kind of selfless decision in his career that led bold journalist Komarov to his untimely death. I now only hope that the murderer and perpetrator of this awful crime is found, prosecuted, and that justice will be served. But that, unfortunately, is only a small and unrealistic hope.

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For most of us, the sounds of a camera taking pictures evokes memories of family gatherings, graduation, smiling with friends, and other fond events. But for one woman, Canadian-Iranian photojournalist Zahra Kazemi, the click of the camera was a prelude to her death. In June 2003, while taking pictures related to the student protests in Iran, Kazemi was arrested on a false accusation. While in custody, she was tortured and eventually brutally murdered. Her story is intricate with elements of Iranian government coverup, eventual revelation of the truth with the help of eyewitnesses, and the heartbreaking aftermath of her loss. The more one learns of her and her story, the more anger is felt. Unlike most photojournalists, Kazemi's focus was mainly on the humanitarian effects caused by political world events, especially on women and children. So, what was done in response to her wrongful killing? Sadly, it appears that almost twenty years later, there has been no justice for Zahra Kazemi's death. Both the governments of Iran and Canada have failed to bring the villains who committed this heinous crime to justice.

Zahra Kazemi, who was born in Shiraz, Iran, was often referred to as "Ziba" by her family and close friends ("Kazemi's Mother"). According to an interview with Kazemi's mother, the aspiring photojournalist studied at a Television University after graduating from high school ("Kazemi's Mother"). While there, she married her husband and moved to France with him in 1974 (CJFE). She studied cinema and literature in college (Stylianou), and eventually got her Ph.D. at Sorbonne University ("Kazemi's Mother"). In 1993, Kazemi and her son, Stephan Hachemi, moved to Canada where she worked as a freelance photojournalist (CPJ).

Although she never worked for any specific press company, Kazemi was a contributor to the Montreal magazine *Recto Verso* and the London photo agency *Camera Press* (CPJ). She would travel around to visit poor countries in the Middle East, Africa, and Central America and take photos (Schmidt). Unlike most photojournalists who take pictures of important people and events, Kazemi's work focused on the daily lives of ordinary citizens in these countries, mainly women and children. This was to emphasize how the policies of the repressive regimes affected the citizens' standard of life and to show how it violated their human rights (Schmidt). In 2013, the 10-year anniversary of his mother's death, Stephan Hachemi compiled a collection of Kazemi's work to honor her memory (Talaga). He stated, "She would go and get to know people, get close to them, get intimate access, to try to show people are just like us" (Talaga).

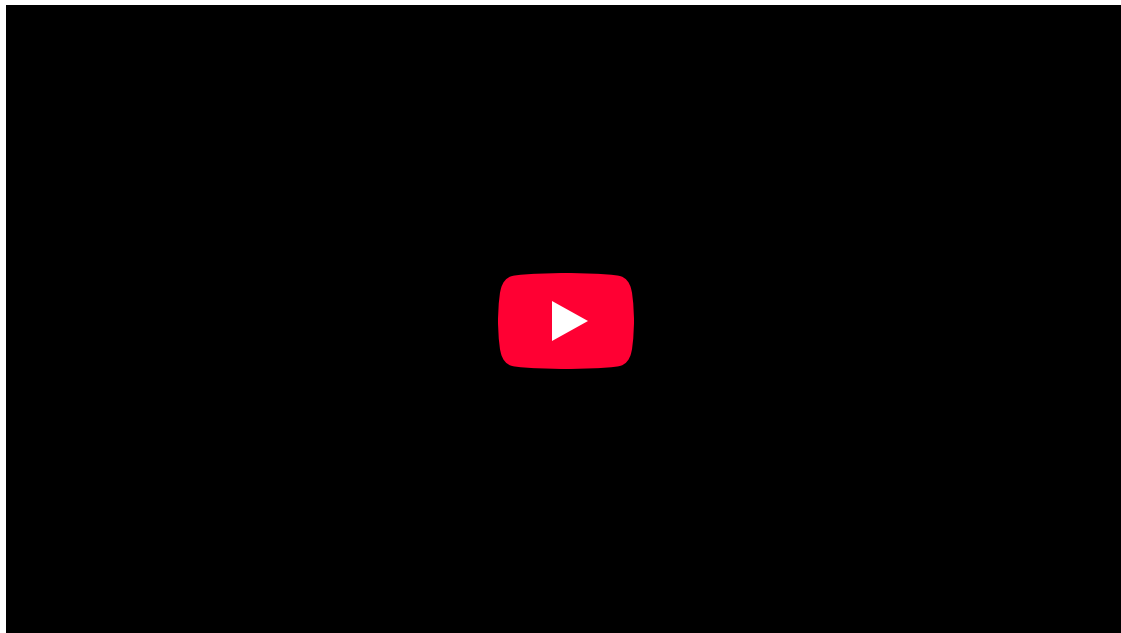
Kazemi's work eventually led her to travel back to her homeland of Iran. In the summer of 2003, the entire country was swamped by student demonstrations (Savyon). These demonstrations were originally peaceful protests opposing the Iranian government's plan to privatize their universities, which would increase tuition fees significantly. However, things soon escalated as the students began expressing their dissatisfaction

with the regime and wanted a more democratic system. This led to them demanding the resignation of Iranian President Mohammad Khatami. As these students were directly and openly opposing a major political figure, the Iranian forces of Basij and Ansar-E Hezbollah started to take action (Savyon). Basij is the paramilitary arm of the Iranian regime, and Ansar-E Hezbollah is an organized group of loyalists to the regime. Both of these groups would break into the university dorms at night to attack students while they were sleeping. They even arrested drivers who honked to show support for the demonstrations (Savyon). Although the regime initially emphasized that the students would not be arrested, Iranian Prosecutor-General Ayatollah Abd Al-Nabi Namazi later came out and stated that over 4000 people had been detained (Savyon).

Since these demonstrations were actively opposing the Iranian regime, the individuals who participated in them were imprisoned in Evin prison, a jail in Tehran notorious for detaining political prisoners. On June 23, Kazemi made her way to the prison to take pictures and interview some of the imprisoned student's families, who were standing outside of the prison (Schmidt). True to her cause, she was more interested in the humanitarian side by showing how the arrests affected the families of the prisoners rather than the purely political side. While photographing the families, security agents from the prison falsely accused her of taking pictures of the prison walls, an action that is considered illegal in Iran. She denied the accusation, however the guards still demanded that she hand over her camera. Since she had been photographing family members of the student prisoners, she was afraid for their fates should the photos fall into the possession of Iranian intelligence (Schmidt). In order to protect those families, she refused to give the agents her camera. This resulted in her arrest (Schmidt).

The guards had approached Kazemi with the claim that she was illegally photographing the Evin Prison walls. Of course, if she had been doing so, the purpose of her arrest would have been legally valid in Iran. But was she actually taking photos as accused? In Kazemi's case, this possibility is not likely for a few different reasons. The first reason centers on her photography work. Please take a look at her photography work in these links and youtube video.

<https://www.gettyimages.ca/detail/news-photo/stephan-hachemi-the-son-of-the-late-zahra-kazemi-a-montreal-news-photo/2722096?phrase=stephan%20hachemi&adppopup=true>
<https://www.gettyimages.ca/detail/ne...&adppopup=true>



back. Infuriated, the woman was transferred to the Evin prison. For a short treatment would be commonly known as the Evin prison. However, as Kazemi was a journalist in the Evin prison, the prosecutor knew this could justify her abuse, and she was taken to the Evin prison. She continued to torture the woman, demanding, and instead of interrogation with the

and abused by the Evin



After viewing, it becomes obvious her work has certain characteristics. Just as an artist has a certain style of painting, Kazemi's pictures all have a common theme: they revolve around ordinary citizens. None of her photos have ever starred a building, landscape, or something mainstream political. Her focus in all the pictures are everyday citizens, especially women and children. It would have been extremely out of character for her to be taking pictures of a prison building. Additionally, the prison guards eventually did gain possession of her camera and the film by the time of her death. If there had been any inkling that she took pictures of the prison wall, the Iranian government would have surely pounced on the fact that she committed a crime in order to justify their actions. Since this topic has never been mentioned by the regime, it's impossible that Kazemi could have photographed the prison walls. The most likely reason the agents arrested her was that they didn't like that a reporter empathized with political prisoners or their families, coupled with the desire to get ahold of the pictures which would reveal the identities of the family members.

As the guards dragged Kazemi inside the prison, they once again demanded she hand over her camera. Once again, she refused. The agent attempted to take it from her by force, a task

prison security guards. What happened to her during this time is a bit unclear. Fortunately, Evin prisoner Behnam Vafaseresht met with the Canadian Embassy to give his account (Petrou). He was imprisoned in January of that year because of his blog posts in support of democracy. He recalls that five months into his imprisonment, while on a hunger strike, he heard the voice of a woman and a man; the woman was screaming, and the man was swearing back at her (Petrou). For two nights, this scene repeated itself, with the woman yelling, "Don't push me! What have I done?" (Petrou) The woman's screaming had transformed into begging and pleading by the third night. Around this time, Vafaseresht was in the hospital ward as his hunger strike had caused him extreme physical harm. While a prison doctor was taking his blood pressure, Vafaseresht saw four men, two of whom held batons, enter the room next door. Vafaseresht recognized one of them to be Mortazavi. The group carried a woman wrapped in a blanket with them (Petrou). When the doctor left for the other room, Vafaseresht overheard an argument among the four men: "Why did you do it?"

"I didn't do anything."

"I didn't hit her that hard." (Petrou)

At some point, Mortazavi became aware of Vafaseresht's presence in the room next door (Petrou). He along with another official began to punch and kick Vafaseresht until he was ordered back to his cell. They then blindfolded him during transit to make sure he didn't see the affair occurring in the other room. However, Vafaseresht could peek out from underneath the blindfold to see a little. He managed to sneak a glance at the blanket-covered woman's files. They were labeled as "Zahra Ziba Kazemi" (Petrou).

On June 27, Kazemi was transferred to the Baghiatollah Hospital under the care of military doctor Shahram Aazam. She lay unconscious on a stretcher and under the guard of an armed soldier (Schmidt). The blanket-covered woman Vafaseresht saw in the prison was now uncovered to be examined by the

horrified doctor. According to Aazam, Kazemi's nose was crushed and surrounded by dried blood, and a large bruise extended from her head to her right ear. The ear itself was swollen and her eardrum had been broken as well (Schmidt). This was most likely the result of the initial strike from the security agent when she first got arrested.

Unfortunately, the signs of torture don't just end there. Kazemi's big toe on her right foot was badly broken, and her feet were bruised with the skin peeling off (Schmidt). Her little and ring finger had been smashed in two separate places. All her fingernails and toenails had been torn off, almost certainly a result from her interrogation torture. Three scratch marks were found on the back of her neck, and yet another bruise extended from her navel to her right thigh (Schmidt). A nurse examined Kazemi's genital area discovered it to be savagely mutilated, which was deduced to be the aftermath of a brutal rape. Furthermore, when Aazam had done a CAT scan, he saw that Kazemi's skull had been fractured twice, which resulted in internal bleeding (Schmidt).

Considering all of the physical harm she had endured, it was sadly no surprise when Kazemi was pronounced braindead the following day (Schmidt). Yet, the hospital had still received orders to keep her on life support. Why? Aazam found the answer to that question when he went to her ward a few days later: her body was looking better. The previously terrible bruises slowly started to heal up (Schmidt). This was Iran's plan of a coverup first came into action. As Aazam stated, "The reason they were keeping her on life support was to reduce the signs of bruising, so that when she went for forensic tests and when the family saw her, she wouldn't look so bad" (Schmidt). On July 3, The Iranian government finally alerted Kazemi's mother, who lived in Shiraz, about the incident. After she had traveled to Tehran to see her daughter, she contacted her grandson Stephan Hachemi, who then notified the Canadian embassy. The Canadian officials were only permitted to see Kazemi through a glass window (Schmidt).

On August 3, 2003, the Toronto Star published an interview with Kazemi's mother, Ezzet. Although the original interview, published in Iranian magazine Yas-e-Nou, was in Farsi, it was translated into English for Canadian readers to understand. According to Kazemi's mother, a woman called to inform her that her daughter was arrested and they wanted her (Ezzet's) house ownership as compensation ("Kazemi's Mother"). When she arrived at Evin Prison, the guards gave her a chador, an open cloak for women, and instructed her to come inside. The guards then gave Ezzet her daughter's purse and camera and told her that she had a brain stroke. Heartbroken, Ezzet asked the guard to give her child's clothing: "I want the dress my child was wearing! She had brown shoes and an Indian dress, a green scarf, black pants, and a brown overcoat. I want everything she was wearing" ("Kazemi's Mother"). The reason she asked for this is unclear; perhaps it's in accord with their culture or religion, or maybe she simply wanted a memory of her daughter.

She then had a back-and-forth with one of the prison guards, with her asking to see her daughter and the guard prohibiting it. The guards brought Ezzet lunch and continued interrogating her ("Kazemi's Mother"), thankfully in a far less violent manner than they did with her daughter.

Half an hour later, the guards finally allowed Ezzet to see her daughter. What she saw before her eyes was any mother's greatest nightmare. Ezzet saw her daughter's eyes shut and her feet wrapped in bandages. A portion of her head was shaved off, and wounds laid underneath her eyes. Just like Dr. Aazam, Kazemi's mother also noticed the large, black bruise on her daughter's thigh and forearm ("Kazemi's Mother"). As she examined her, the guards informed Ezzet that Kazemi was in a coma. In comparison, Kazemi looked slightly better now than initially when Dr. Aazam first saw her. Nevertheless, for a mother to behold the sight of her daughter's beaten body must have been remembered as a mother's greatest terror. Ezzet wanted to know why her daughter's arm was bruised ("Kazemi's Mother"). The prison guard claimed that it was from an injection, but Ezzet retorted back. "Are you kidding me? The injection was on the inside of her elbow. Why is her upper arm bruised?" ("Kazemi's Mother") In the days following, Ezzet would come to the hospital to visit her daughter ("Kazemi's Mother"), until July 11, when Kazemi was taken off life support and died at age 54 (Schmidt).

Now that Kazemi was officially pronounced dead, the Iranian government would have to account for her death. As Aazam stated, "She's a reporter; she was arrested healthy and now she's here smashed and injured all over" (Schmidt). If the true story of her death ever got exposed, the regime would be the center of an international incident. As a result, they desperately tried to cover up her death, starting out by falsely claiming a natural stroke as the cause of her death. In fact, Saeed Mortazavi was quoted stating that Kazemi died due to a stroke (Lancaster). Although it is technically true that she died from internal brain bleeding, her body showed signs of torture leading to a skull fracture. Any third-party that examined Kazemi's body would be able to deduce that her brain hemorrhage was caused by abuse and beatings. In an attempt of preventing that scenario, the Iranian officials forced her mother to agree to have Kazemi's body buried in Iran (Schmidt). This way, the Canadian Embassy wouldn't be able to perform an autopsy on the deceased photojournalist.

Ezzet was initially reluctant and allowed the Canadian officials to have Kazemi be returned to Canada ("Kazemi's Mother"). She later was forced by the Iranian officials into having her daughter's burial in Iran (NCRI). When asked about it in an interview, Ezzet recalls that while she stayed over at a friend's house in Tehran, Iranian agents would come over daily and harass her host in order to persuade her ("Kazemi's Mother"). "I was forced to agree. I was alone with no money and nowhere to go," she said during the interview ("Kazemi's Mother"). Naturally, Kazemi's son strongly disagreed with the burial and

demanding that his mother be returned to Canada. He was well aware of the situation that his grandmother was placed in. The two had regular conversations over the phone, but Hachemi knew that the Iranian government was listening into their conversations (Sallot and Peritz). He was quoted saying, "It has been clear between us, and all the members of the family, that [Ms. Kazemi] won't be buried in the land of the people who murdered her. (Sallot and Peritz)" However, despite his objections, Kazemi's body was still buried on July 23, 2003, in her hometown of Shiraz (NCRI). Ezzet said that the Iranian doctors had performed an autopsy on her daughter's body, without permission. While her body was being washed for the funeral, it apparently bled as a result of the autopsy ("Kazemi's Mother").

The topic of Kazemi's death had inevitably become an international matter of interest. The director of foreign press and media, Mohammad Hoseyn Khoshvaqt, followed Mortazavi's lead and stated that Kazemi died of a stroke to the reporters (Schmidt). He later testified that Mortazavi had threatened him to make that claim (NCRI). Four days later, however, President Khatami contradicted Khoshvaqt's statement by affirming that the photojournalist died from "a brain hemorrhage resulting from beatings (Schmidt)." He most likely caved and told the truth because of the pressure placed on him by the rest of the world, as Kazemi's death became known around the world. On July 13, President Khatami held an inquiry discussing the circumstances of Kazemi's death (Schmidt). Ironically, Mortazavi, the very man who ordered her torture, was also the person put in charge of Kazemi's investigation (Gatehouse). Unfortunately, the inquiry ended less than a week later with no one being held accountable, as the ministry decided that Kazemi had died due to a "fractured skull, brain hemorrhage, and its consequences resulting from a hard object hitting her head or her head hitting a hard object (Schmidt)."

After this pathetic and compromised investigation, Iran went silent in regard to Kazemi's case. It wasn't until July 28, 2003, an entire year later, that this topic was brought back into light. This time, low-level intelligence Reza Aghdam Ahmadi was charged with beating Kazemi to death (Lancaster). After his trial was concluded, the judiciary cleared him of any charges and officially decided that "the death of the late Kazemi was an accident due to a fall in blood pressure resulting from a hunger strike and her fall on the ground while standing" (Schmidt). Just like the investigation conducted a year before, this pathetic trial ended without any justice, and Iran went silent once again. Fortunately, in July of 2005, Nobel Peace Prize-winning lawyer Shirin Ebadi, the head of team representing Kazemi's family, asked to have Kazemi's case reopened as one of first-degree murder (Schmidt). Nevertheless, the judge rejected Ebadi's appeal, and thus officially concluded Iran's investigation into Kazemi's death.

One would expect that since Kazemi was a Canadian citizen, the Canadian government would take action to discover the truth

about her death. In fact, Jean Chrétien, the Prime Minister of Canada at the time, was quoted saying, "If crimes have been committed, we are demanding of the Iranian government to punish those who committed the crime, and we will push that case" (Sallot and Peritz). In the beginning, the Canadian Embassy tried to get involved with Iran's investigation of Kazemi's death. Unsurprisingly, the Iranian government tried to block them at every turn, despite claiming they would inform the Canadians of any new developments. The regime denied in allowing the Canadian Embassy to assist with Kazemi's forensics, claiming they were, "competent to conduct their own criminal investigation" (Sallot and Peritz).

Naturally, the Iranians conviction to exclude the Canadians from participating in the forensics would pose a challenge to the Canadian government helping bring justice to Kazemi and her family. However, there are other ways besides taking part of the investigation that would provide proof against the Iranian regime. For one, it seemed painfully obvious that Mortazavi was responsible for Kazemi's murder. After all, he was already infamous in Iran for imprisoning, torturing, and oftentimes ordering the murder of reporters (Gatehouse). The fact that he was also the one who ordered Kazemi's arrest and torture, as well as overseeing her death investigation, should have been a red flag that Mortazavi has Kazemi's blood on his hands. There were a couple whistleblowers who could testify to Mortazavi's involvement in Kazemi's murder. Vafaseresht, the person who was in Evin prison at the time of Kazemi's arrest and recognized Mortazavi among the men who orchestrated her death, would be an invaluable witness in a legal case against the Iranian regime. However, other than meeting with him once for his account, the Canadian Embassy has yet to contact him again (Petrou). Dr. Aazam, who has moved to Canada with his family, is openly willing to testify against Mortazavi. Once again, the Canadian government never reached out to him to ask about the Kazemi case since he left Iran (Petrou).

Mortazavi did eventually get placed in prison, but it wasn't by the push of the Canadian government. As a matter of fact, his arrest had nothing to do with Kazemi's case at all. On November 26, 2016, the Iranian government decided he had to spend two years in prison for the death of Mohsen Rouhnamini. Mohsen was arrested in a 2009 demonstration and died from beatings in a detention center ("Butcher"). Was Mohsen Rouhnamini also a journalist? Actually, the answer is no. Unlike Kazemi's death, the Iranian regime took action for Mohsen's death because his father, Abdolhossein Rouhnamini, was an important Iranian politician. Although it took almost eight years for any results, Mortazavi was finally, with much effort from Rouhnamini, sentenced to serve only two years in prison ("Butcher"). Interestingly, even in that case, the Iranian government tried to let Mortazavi off the hook by claiming he was "missing" and couldn't be found after his sentencing. When the Iranian citizens heard this news, they began taping up "wanted posters" of Mortazavi, clearly wanting him to be found and imprisoned. Rouhnamini most likely also wanted the

former chief prosecutor to be sent to jail, as he was found two years later and began serving his sentence in prison on April 21, 2021 ("Butcher").

If even the corrupt Iranian regime could finally bring some form of justice for one of their own men, the Canadian government could surely do more and at the very least hold the Iranians responsible for Kazemi's death. However, instead of pursuing it, the Canadian government had silently dropped Kazemi's case and turned a blind eye. Despite their earlier claims that they would serve justice at any cost, results have yet to be seen. On the 10-year anniversary of her death, Foreign Affairs Minister John Baird said that Canada has not forgotten about Zahra Kazemi, and stated, "Her memory strengthens our resolve to seek long-awaited justice in her case. It reminds us of all those still languishing as political prisoners in Iranian jails and compels us to keep exerting pressure on the regime in Tehran to take concrete steps to address the egregious state of human rights in Iran and to face the Iranian people's desire for change. (Talaga)" Yet, what actions have the Canadian government taken to seek justice? Earlier this year, Canadian Prime Minister Justin Trudeau announced that 10,000 Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps would be forever banned from entering Canada (Robertson). Among these individuals are Mortazavi and 20 other Iranian officials. This ban has so far been the most action the Canadian government has taken against Iran, and it still doesn't hold anyone accountable for Kazemi's death. As Stephan Hachemi stated in 2013, "The Iranian government did what they did because they could. They knew the Canadian government would let them do whatever they want. They knew very well they'd still be able to sell their gas and make deals with Canadian companies. They didn't hesitate and they weren't wrong. There were no real consequences" (Talaga). Sadly, this statement has so far remained true.

Today the year is 2022. Almost twenty years have passed since Zahra Kazemi was arrested for a crime she never committed. She was beaten, raped, and murdered for doing nothing other than dare defy an Iranian agent in order to protect innocent families. For twenty years, a mother has been wrongfully robbed of her daughter. For twenty years, a son has been tragically torn from his mother. Most tragically, no one has ever been held accountable for this crime against humanity. Those who orchestrated Kazemi's death have never been convicted of her murder, and the country she had lived in for almost 30 years has done nothing to fight for her justice. It's time for Canada to answer for their lack of action. When will Kazemi's body be returned to Canada in line with the wishes of her family? When will Kazemi's murders finally be prosecuted for her death? Canada, when will justice for Zahra Kazemi finally be served?

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What does real risk look like? Is risk just getting out of your comfort zone, is it putting your life in danger for others, or is it somewhere in between? For the Mexican reporter Julio Valdivia, real risk was giving your life to help inform others. Julio Valdivia gave his life in the line of duty as a reporter for the Mexican news company, El Mundo. Valdivia joined El Mundo in 2014. There he, "was the regional correspondent for the newspaper in Tezonapa" (The John S. and James L. Knight Foundation Press, 2021). Julio Valdivia is known today for his heroic reports on crime and safety in Tezonapa and his tragic death at the hands of gang violence.

Julio Valdivia joined as a simple reporter who reported on many things in his life, but what he will be remembered for are his reports on the crime and safety (or lack thereof) in Tezonapa. A report on the area of Tezonapa recently states that, "Tezonapa has seen a significant spike in deadly violence this year," (The John S. and James L. Knight Foundation Press, 2021). This spike in violence is what brings Valdivia to this area, as he is sent to report on the gang clashes and oil theft. Additionally this violence is what causes the death of many local sugar cane farmers, which also make their way into reports. Julio Valdivia, "specialized in 'nota roja' journalism, focusing on grisly stories in a state plagued by gang violence" (Woods, 2020). Once again, this demonstrates the risk Julio Valdivia faced to share the story.

Unfortunately this coverage of gangs and violence is what would lead him to his death.

Julio Valdivia was "found murdered and decapitated close to train tracks on Wednesday, September 9," (Ghose, 2020). Reports also suggest that Valdivia had been run over by the train, as his company provided motorcycle that he left on that morning, was found nearby. After the local government took to Twitter about the murder they disprove any theories of the train, as well as no mention of his head being found. Horrified social media users left several comments, one of which being, "If you want to hurt someone you hurt what they love if you want to

send a message you hurt that person if you want to send a warning, you mutilate that person" and "He must have known too much. So sad. The assault (sic) on journalists needs to stop!" (Ghose, 2020)

Unfortunately, there is not much information about Julio Valdivia's death other than what has already been mentioned. There is much mystery still surrounding this case. Things such as, "What gang is responsible for this heinous act?" and "What did he know to make him a target?" still have yet to be answered. Valdivia will be known for his courageous reports on gang violence and their crimes, his drive to risk it all for the story and will be forever mourned. However, to some of us now, Julio Valdivia will be remembered as a man who knew what real risk is.

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